

Day 6 — *Pr̥thivī Sūkta*: Earth as Mother (Atharva Veda 12.1)

Module: Indic Ecology · **Band:** Middle · **Time:** 45 min

Learning objective

Students read selected verses from the *Pr̥thivī Sūkta* (AV 12.1) in translation, identify three concrete images the hymn uses for the Earth, and articulate the difference between *spiritual* and *empirical* claims about the planet.

Materials

- Printed handout: AV 12.1 selections (verses 1, 12, 35, 63) in IAST + translation, one per student
- Notebook
- Optional: a small bowl of soil, a cup of water, a leaf — placed at the front of the room

Vocabulary

- *Pr̥thivī* (IAST: *pr̥thivī*) — Earth, also the goddess Earth. Same word as Module 2’s *pr̥thivī*, here as proper name.
- *sūkta* (IAST: *sūkta*; lit. “well-spoken, hymn”) — a Vedic hymn; one of the units of the R̥g / Atharva collections.
- *mātā* (IAST: *mātā*) — mother.
- *bhūmi* (IAST: *bhūmi*) — earth, land. Used as a synonym for *pr̥thivī*.
- *ṛta* (IAST: *ṛta*) — cosmic order, the way things rightly are. Older companion of *dharma*.

Lesson flow

Warm-up (5 min)

- Show the bowl of soil. Pass around for 1 minute — students smell, touch (not taste).
- “*This is what we are about to call our mother. Hold it. What does that feel like?*”
- Take 2–3 responses. Don’t moralise.

Core (20 min)

1. **Position the text.** The *Pr̥thivī Sūkta* is the longest single hymn in the Atharva Veda — 63 verses — addressed entirely to the Earth. The composition is dated to roughly the late Vedic period (c. 1200–1000 BCE in conventional chronology). It is one of the earliest extensive ecological texts in any tradition.
2. **Read four verses on the handout** (selections — the full 63 are too many for one period):

AV 12.1.12: > “*mātā bhūmih putro aham̐ pr̥thivyāḥ*” > “Earth is the mother. I am the son of Earth.”

AV 12.1.1 (paraphrase from Griffith / Whitney translation): > “Truth (*satya*), cosmic order (*ṛta*), discipline (*dīkṣā*), spiritual heat (*tapas*), prayer (*brahman*), and sacrifice (*yajña*) — these sustain the Earth. May this Earth, who is mistress of what has been and what shall be, make a wide place for us.”

AV 12.1.35: > “Whatever I dig from you, O Earth, may it grow back quickly. May I not strike your vitals or your heart.”

AV 12.1.63 (concluding verse, paraphrased): > “O Earth, my mother — set me down upon a well-founded place. With heaven for cooperator, O wise one, place me in fortune and in prosperity.”

3. **Notice the imagery.** Ask students to identify, in their notebook:

- A line that treats Earth as a *person* (mother, who supports, who has vitals).
- A line that names *what humans owe back* (the dug-up matter should grow back; we shouldn’t strike vitals).
- A line that lists *abstract things sustained by Earth* (truth, order, discipline, sacrifice).

4. **The honest analysis — spiritual claim vs. empirical claim.**

Claim	Type	How you’d test it
“Earth is the mother.”	Spiritual / ethical	You don’t test it. It’s a stance.
“Soil takes 100–1000 years to form 1 cm.”	Empirical	Soil-science measurement.
“Whatever I dig from Earth, may it grow back.”	Ethical (with an empirical implication)	Implies a sustainability check.
“I should not strike Earth’s vitals.”	Ethical	Implies don’t mine recklessly.

The first kind of claim is not better or worse than the second. It does different work. The first shapes your attitude. The second checks whether you actually behaved well.

5. **Why this hymn matters now.** AV 12.1 is sometimes called the world’s first comprehensive ecological hymn. That’s a bold claim — but the verse structure does cover:

- Earth as living (mother).
- Reciprocity (give back what you dug).
- Sacred limits (don’t strike vitals).
- Sustenance via abstract principles (truth, order).

This is unusual for any tradition’s earliest texts. Pre-modern poetry typically extracts; this hymn asks for permission and asks for forgiveness.

Activity (15 min) — Imagery Analysis Worksheet

- In pairs, students fill in a 2-column worksheet:

Verse / image	What modern observation is this in line with?
“Mother who supports us”	Soil supports food chains; the biosphere supports all life.
“May what I dig grow back”	Renewable extraction limits; sustainability.
“Don’t strike Earth’s vitals”	Don’t destroy groundwater aquifers; don’t damage the ozone layer; don’t push past climate tipping points.
“Earth is the support of truth, order, discipline”	The biosphere is the precondition for any human civilization, including science.

- The point is *not* “the Vedas predicted climate science.” The point is that thoughtful pre-modern writers asked questions whose answers we are now measuring. Recognising the overlap honours both sides.

Wrap-up (5 min)

- Reflection prompt** (slip of paper, 3 sentences): “*Today I read a hymn that calls the Earth my mother. Did this change anything I felt? Be honest — yes, no, or ‘I’m not sure.’*”
- Preview Day 7: “*Tomorrow — what does it mean to enjoy what is given, but not grab? One verse from the Īśa Upaniṣad.*”

Student-facing content

The *Pr̥thivī Sūkta* — Atharva Veda 12.1.

A 63-verse hymn addressed to the Earth. Some lines you should know:

“Earth is the mother. I am the son of Earth.” (AV 12.1.12)

“Whatever I dig from you, O Earth, may it grow back quickly. May I not strike your vitals or your heart.” (AV 12.1.35)

The hymn is **spiritual** in form — it speaks to the Earth as a person. It is **ecological** in implication — it asks for reciprocity, limits, and forgiveness for what we extract.

Spiritual statements (“Earth is our mother”) and empirical statements (“soil takes 500 years to form 1 cm”) do different work. The first shapes how we *attend*. The second tells us whether we are actually behaving well. Both matter.

Homework

- Read all four verses on your handout one more time. Write **one verse of your own** — 2 lines, addressed to one specific bit of nature near your home (a tree, a tap, a patch of grass). Use the *Pr̥thivī Sūkta* structure: “*You are X. I am Y. May I not Z.*”

Differentiation

- **One tier up:** Compare AV 12.1.35 (“may what I dig grow back”) with one principle of “regenerative agriculture” (you can summarise from a 5-minute online search). Are these the same claim or different?
- **One tier down:** Focus on one image — “Earth is the mother. I am her child.” That’s enough to anchor the whole lesson.

Teacher notes

- This is the lesson where students most often slide into one of two unhelpful positions: (1) “this is just poetry, not real,” or (2) “this is divine truth and modern science is missing it.” Neither is right. The hymn is *poetry that carries an ethic*. The ethic happens to be in line with what we now know empirically about how ecosystems work.
- The “may I not strike your vitals” verse (AV 12.1.35) is the most operationally useful one. Don’t skip it.
- Some students will ask if the Earth is “literally” alive. Two honest answers exist: (a) no, in the strict biological sense (the planet doesn’t reproduce, metabolise, etc.); (b) yes, in the Gaia-hypothesis sense (the biosphere as a whole self-regulates). Both are respectable positions. The hymn is closer to (b) in spirit but doesn’t depend on either.
- The full 63-verse hymn is available in Whitney’s *Atharva-Veda Samhitā* translation (Harvard Oriental Series 1905) — public domain. Bring more verses if students want them.

Citation(s) used in this lesson

- **Atharva Veda 12.1.12, 12.1.1, 12.1.35, 12.1.63** — quoted / paraphrased. Translations adapted from W. D. Whitney’s *Atharva-Veda Samhitā* (Harvard Oriental Series 1905, public domain) and R. T. H. Griffith’s *Hymns of the Atharvaveda* (1895–96).
- See [sources.md](#) for the edition note and the Chapple & Tucker (2000) anthology for teacher background.